Praise to the Dharmadhātu

Dharmadhātustava · Toh 1118 · Derge Tengyur
ཆོས་ཀྱི་དབྱིངས་སུ་བྱས་པའོ།།

The Praise to the Dharmadhātu, known in Sanskrit as the Dharmadhātustava and in Tibetan as Chökyi Ying su Töpa, is a hymn in verse that its colophon attributes to the great master Nāgārjuna, translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator Tsultrim Gyalwa. It praises the dharmadhātu, the basic nature of reality present in every sentient being, which, while veiled by the afflictions, is the cause of wandering in saṃsāra, and which, once purified, is itself nirvāṇa and the dharmakāya. Through a series of images, such as butter hidden in milk, a swan drawing milk from water, and the waxing of the moon, it shows how this nature is uncovered through the perfections and the ten bodhisattva grounds until it is fully revealed as the dharmakāya. It is Toh 1118 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises, or stotra, and it is counted among the hymns traditionally ascribed to Nāgārjuna.

In the language of India: dharmadhātustavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise to the Dharmadhātu

Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī, the Youthful.

When it is not fully known,
One circles through the three realms of existence;
To that dharmadhātu (the basic space of phenomena), surely present in all sentient beings,
I pay homage and bow down.

That which has become the cause of saṃsāra,
When it is purified,
That very purity is nirvāṇa,
And the Dharma body too is just that.

Just as, being mixed with milk,
The essence of butter does not appear,
So, being mixed with the afflictions,
The dharmadhātu is not seen.

Just as, when the milk is thoroughly purified,
The essence of butter becomes stainless,
So, when the afflictions are thoroughly purified,

The dharmadhātu becomes utterly stainless.

Just as a lamp that sits inside a vase
Does not shine out in the least,
So, sitting inside the vase of the afflictions,
The dharmadhātu is not seen.

From whichever sides
Holes are pierced in the vase,
From just those sides
Its intrinsic nature of light shines forth.

When, by the vajra of meditative absorption,
That vase has been shattered,
Then it shines forth
To the very ends of space.

The dharmadhātu is not born,
Nor will it ever cease;
At all times it is free of affliction,
Stainless in the beginning, middle, and end.

Just as the precious vaiḍūrya gem
Is luminous at all times,
Yet when it lies within rock
Its light does not shine,

So the dharmadhātu, obscured by the afflictions,
Though utterly stainless,
Does not shine its light in saṃsāra,
But in nirvāṇa becomes luminous.

If the element is present, then by working at it
Pure gold will be seen;
If the element is absent, working at it
Only produces afflictions.

Just as grain that is covered by its husk
Is not regarded as the fruit,
So, covered by the afflictions,
It is not called "buddha."

Just as, when it is freed from the husk,
The fruit itself appears,
So, when freed from the afflictions,
The Dharma body itself shines forth clearly.

Although in the world the plantain tree
Is given as the example of what has no core,
Its fruit is the very core,
And just as people eat it for its sweetness,

So from coreless saṃsāra,
Once it is freed from the cage of the afflictions,
Its fruit, buddhahood itself,
Becomes nectar for all embodied beings.

Likewise, from every seed
Comes a fruit resembling its cause;
That there could be fruit without a seed,
What person of understanding could prove?

That very element, which is the seed,
Is held to be the basis of all phenomena;
Through its being purified step by step,
The state of buddhahood is attained.

Even the stainless sun and moon
Are obscured by five obscurations:
Clouds, mist, and smoke,
The face of Rāhu (the eclipse demon), dust, and the like.

Likewise the luminous mind
Is obscured by five obscurations:
Desire, malice, and laziness,
Agitation, and doubt.

Just as a garment that is cleansed by fire,
When stained with various stains
And placed in the fire,
Has its stains burned away, but not the garment,

So too the luminous mind
Is stained with attachment and the rest;
The fire of wisdom burns the afflictions,

But not that luminosity itself.

All the sūtras teaching emptiness,
However many the Victor has spoken,
Turn back the afflictions;
They do not impair this element.

Just as water deep within the ground
Remains free of impurity,
So too wisdom within the afflictions
Remains free of stain.

Since the dharmadhātu is not a self,
Is neither woman nor man,
And is wholly free from everything grasped,
How could one imagine it as a self?

In all phenomena, free of attachment,
Neither woman nor man is found;
For the sake of disciples blinded by desire,
"Woman" and "man" are taught.

The three called "impermanent," "suffering," and "empty"
Purify the mind;
The Dharma that purifies the mind supremely
Is the absence of intrinsic nature.

Just as a child in a pregnant woman's womb,
Though present, is not seen,
So the dharmadhātu, covered by the afflictions,
Is not seen either.

Through conceptions of "self" and "mine,"
Perceptions of names, and signs,
The four conceptions arise;
And their arising, too, is due to the elements and what derives from the elements.

Even the aspirations of the buddhas
Are without appearance and without characteristics;
Joined in union with individual self-awareness,
The buddhas possess the permanent nature of reality.

Just as the horn on a rabbit's head
Is merely imagined and does not exist,
So too all phenomena
Are merely imagined and do not exist.

Nor is the horn of an ox found
In the nature of its smallest particles;
As it was before, so it is after:
What is there to imagine about it?

Since things arise in dependence
And cease in dependence,
When not even one of them exists,
How can the childish imagine them?

Through the examples of the horns of the rabbit and the ox,
This is how the Sugata (the Buddha) establishes phenomena themselves
As the Middle Way.

Just as the forms of the sun, moon, and stars
Are seen as reflections
In the water of a clear vessel,
So too are the perfect characteristics.

That which is virtuous in the beginning, middle, and end,
Undeceiving and steadfast,
And thus selfless too,
How could it be imagined as "self" and "mine"?

Just as in summertime water
Is spoken of as "warm,"
While that same water in the cold season
Is spoken of as "cold,"

So what is covered by the net of afflictions
Is to be called a "sentient being,"
And when that very thing is free of afflictions,
It is to be called a "buddha."

In dependence on the eye and forms,
Stainless appearances arise;
From their very nonarising and nonceasing,
The dharmadhātu is fully known.

In dependence on sound and the ear,
The pure threefold cognition,
The dharmadhātu without characteristics,
Comes to be heard through conceptual thought.

In dependence on the nose and odor, one smells;
That is an example of what has no form;
Likewise, through the nose consciousness,
One conceives the dharmadhātu.

The intrinsic nature of the tongue is emptiness,
And the element of taste is void as well;
This is the very essence of the dharmadhātu,
And consciousness has no abode.

The essence of the pure body
And the characteristic of tangible conditions:
What is freed from conditions
Is to be called the dharmadhātu.

With regard to phenomena in which the mind is foremost,
Having abandoned conceiving and imputing,
The very lack of intrinsic nature in phenomena
Should be meditated on as the dharmadhātu.

When what is seen, heard, and smelled,
What is tasted and touched,
And phenomena are known in this way by the yogin,
The characteristics are perfect.

Eye, ear, and nose,
Tongue, body, and likewise mind:
These six sense sources, fully purified,
Are themselves the characteristic of suchness.

The mind itself is seen in two ways,
As worldly and as beyond the world;
Grasping at a self, it is saṃsāra;
Known individually, it is suchness.

With the exhaustion of desire there is nirvāṇa;
And with aversion and delusion exhausted,
Their cessation is buddhahood itself,

The very refuge of all embodied beings.

Through knowing and not knowing,
Everything is in this very body;
Bound by one's own conceptual thought,
One is freed by knowing one's own nature.

Awakening is neither far nor near;
It neither goes nor comes;
In this very cage of afflictions
It is either seen or not seen.

"Abiding in the lamp of wisdom,
One who has become supremely peaceful
Should dwell examining the self":
So it is taught in the collections of the sūtras.

By the strength of the ten powers the childish are blessed;
Like the moon in the first days of the month,
The Tathāgata is not seen
By sentient beings with afflictions.

Just as pretas (hungry ghosts)
See the ocean as dry,
So those obscured by ignorance
Imagine that the buddhas do not exist.

For the lowly and those of meager merit,
What can the Blessed One do?
It is like placing the supreme jewel
In the hand of one born blind.

For sentient beings who have made merit,
The Buddha, radiant with light and glorious,
Blazing with the thirty-two major marks,
Abides before them.

Though the Protector, in his form body,
Remains for many eons,
It is to train those to be trained
That the expanse itself has become diverse.

Having ascertained the domain of the mind,
Cognition enters into it;
When individual self-awareness is fully pure,
The grounds abide as its very nature.

The supreme abode of Maheśvara
And Akaniṣṭha (the highest heaven), utterly beautiful:
There the three cognitions
Have merged into one, I declare.

Omniscience among the childish,
Diversity itself among the noble ones,
Maheśvara and Amitāyus:
What is the cause of their lives that last for eons?

That by which the life, too,
Of the outer realm of sentient beings
Is protected for immeasurable eons,
And by which the life force of living creatures endures:

That inexhaustible cause itself,
Whose fruit is inexhaustible,
Through the distinction of nonappearance,
Is fully entered as the object of wisdom.

One should not think of awakening as far,
Nor should one think of it as near;
It is without the appearance of the six objects
That it is known exactly as it truly is.

Just as, from water mixed with milk
Standing in a single vessel,
A swan will drink the milk
But not the water, which remains as it was,

So too, though primordial wisdom, covered by afflictions,
Dwells as one with them in this body,
The yogin takes up primordial wisdom
And casts away ignorance.

As long as there is clinging to "I" and "mine,"
Through it the external is imagined;
When the twofold selflessness is seen,

The seed of existence will cease.

Because of it there is the nirvāṇa of the buddhas,
Pure, permanent, the basis of virtue;
Because of it the childish imagine two;
The yogin abides in its nonduality.

Generosity with its many hardships,
Moral discipline that gathers benefit for beings,
And patience that helps beings:
Through these three the element will grow.

Diligence toward all dharmas,
The mind's engagement in meditative concentration,
And constant reliance on wisdom:
These too make awakening grow.

Wisdom joined with skillful means,
Thoroughly purified aspiration,
Firmness in power, and primordial wisdom:
These are the four dharmas that make the element grow.

To say, "Do not pay homage to the mind of awakening,"
Is to speak wrongly;
For unless bodhisattvas come forth,
The dharmakāya does not arise.

Whoever scorns the sugarcane seed
Yet wishes to enjoy sugar:
Without the sugarcane seed,
Sugar will not come about.

Just as, when the sugarcane seed is protected,
Tended, and cultivated,
Molasses, sugar, and candied sugar
Come forth from it,

So, when the mind of awakening is well protected,
Tended, and cultivated,
Arhats, pratyekabuddhas, and buddhas
Are born and come forth from it.

Just as farmers protect
The seeds of rice and other crops,
So the Guides (the buddhas) protect
Those devoted to the supreme vehicle.

Just as on the fourteenth day of the waning moon
The moon is seen only a little,
So, for those devoted to the supreme vehicle,
The buddha body is seen only a little.

Just as the waxing moon
Is seen to grow moment by moment,
So those who have entered the grounds
Are seen to increase step by step.

Just as on the fifteenth day of the waxing moon
The moon becomes full,
So when the grounds reach their end,
The dharmakāya too is complete and clear.

Through constant, steadfast devotion
To the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha,
That mind is truly generated,
And again and again it arises, never to turn back.

Having entirely abandoned the black basis
And firmly taken up the white basis,
At that time it is realized with certainty
And is designated "Joyful."

What was always stained
By the various stains of attachment and the rest,
Once it is pure and free of stains,
Is called "Stainless."

Once the net of afflictions has fully ceased,
Stainless wisdom shines brightly,
And because it dispels boundless darkness,
It is "Illuminating."

Always bright with pure light,
And wholly encircled by the light of primordial wisdom
That has given up all bustle,

That ground is held to be "Radiant."

All sciences, arts, and crafts,
And the many kinds of meditative concentration;
Because it has triumphed over the afflictions,
So very hard to master, it is held to be "Hard to Master."

Since the three kinds of awakening,
The gathering of all excellences,
And the exhaustion of arising and perishing are made manifest,
That ground is held to be "Manifest."

Because it plays everywhere with nets of light
In the array of a wheel,
And has crossed the mire of the ocean of saṃsāra,
It is called "Gone Afar."

It is firmly held by the buddhas,
Has entered the ocean of primordial wisdom,
Is effortless and spontaneously accomplished,
And cannot be moved by the retinue of Māra.

Because that yogin has reached perfection
In all the discriminating awarenesses
And in discourse that teaches the Dharma,
That ground is held to be "Excellent Intelligence."

Its body, whose intrinsic nature is primordial wisdom,
Is equal to stainless space,
And from the holding of the buddhas
The Cloud of Dharma arises everywhere.

The abode of the buddhas' qualities,
Which fully holds the fruit of practice,
That transformation of the basis
Is what is called the dharmakāya.

Free of habitual tendencies, it is inconceivable;
The habitual tendencies of saṃsāra can be conceived.
You are inconceivable in every way:
Who could ever know you?

Beyond every domain of speech,
Not the domain of any of the senses,
To be realized by mental consciousness:
Whatever it may be, I bow to it and praise it.

Following the way of gradual entry,
The greatly renowned children of the buddhas,
Through the primordial wisdom of the Cloud of Dharma,
Come to see the empty nature of reality.

When the mind has been thoroughly cleansed
And has passed beyond the cage of saṃsāra,
Such a one comes to rest
Upon a seat whose nature is a great lotus.

Its petals glow with the light of many jewels,
Its anthers are delightful,
And on every side it is encircled
By many tens of millions of lotuses.

Those who are completely filled with the ten powers
And brimming with the fearlessnesses
Never fall away from the inconceivable
Buddha qualities, free of elaboration.

The full moon who, through all the paths well practiced,
Has amassed merit and primordial wisdom
Is encircled on every side
By the stars as its retinue.

There, in the sunlike hands of the buddhas,
Stainless jewels blaze,
And empowering him as their eldest son,
They bestow empowerment in full.

Abiding there, that great yogin
Beholds with his divine eye
The worlds, debased by delusion,
Distracted and terrified by suffering.

Then from his body rays of light
Come forth without effort,
And for those who have entered the darkness of delusion

He opens the doors.

Those in nirvāṇa with remainder
Hold to nirvāṇa without remainder;
But here nirvāṇa itself
Is the mind become free of stains.

The nature of all sentient beings,
Which is without entity, is its domain as well;
The lord of the mind of awakening who sees it
Is the utterly stainless dharmakāya.

When the ocean of primordial wisdom
Abides in the stainless dharmakāya,
From it, just as from jewels of every kind,
The benefit of sentient beings is perfectly accomplished.

This completes the Praise to the Dharmadhātu, composed by the great master Nāgārjuna. It was translated by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Translator's Notes

• The verse on the horns of the rabbit and the ox has only three lines in this text and is translated as it stands. Maheśvara here names the lord of the supreme abode at the summit of the form realm, which the verse pairs with Akaniṣṭha. The closing verses are read as a question, "What is the cause of their lives that last for eons?", answered in the two verses that follow: it is the inexhaustible cause that is entered as the object of wisdom.
• In the verse on paying homage, byang chub sems ("the mind of awakening") may stand for bodhisattva, as the lines that follow suggest. The lines rendered "Those in nirvāṇa with remainder hold to nirvāṇa without remainder" can also be read as reporting the view that nirvāṇa is of two kinds, with and without remainder, which the verse then contrasts with nirvāṇa as the mind become stainless. Likewise byang chub sems dbang po, rendered "the lord of the mind of awakening," may mean "the lord among bodhisattvas."

Colophon

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spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.